

Accessibility Evaluation — I Work for NSW

WCAG 2.2 Level AA • WCAG-EM methodology • Independent evaluation

Evaluation title	Accessibility Evaluation — I Work for NSW (public website)
Website	I Work for NSW — https://iworkfor.nsw.gov.au/
Scope	Homepage of the I Work for NSW jobs website.
Conformance target	WCAG 2.2 Level AA
Accessibility-support baseline	VoiceOver + Safari (primary) on macOS and iOS (iPhone); spot-checked in Chrome on macOS; keyboard + Safari/Chrome.
Pages evaluated	Homepage
Evaluator	Tatiana Shukletsova
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Overall summary

The site has a good base to build on. The layout is clean, the content is inclusive, and some accessibility basics are already there: skip links, landmarks and image alt text.

However, the homepage does not yet meet WCAG 2.2 Level AA.

The keyboard problems are the most important and should be fixed first. Many people rely only on a keyboard, and right now several things block them: the mobile menu can't be opened by keyboard, the search dropdowns can't be fully used, and there's no visible focus on most of the page.

Most issues come from two causes, so fixing these solves many findings at once:

1. The focus outline seems to be switched off across the whole site. Adding a clear focus style back fixes the focus problems in one change.
2. The search dropdowns are custom-built and don't work properly with keyboard or screen readers. Rebuilding them the standard way fixes most of the dropdown findings.

I suggest fixing the keyboard and focus issues first, then the rest.

Conformance overview

Findings by severity				
Critical: 1	Serious: 12	Moderate: 9	Minor: 3	Total: 25
Criteria passed				23
Criteria failed				9
Cannot tell				0
Not applicable				23
Applicable (Pass+Fail+Cannot tell)				32
Criteria met (of applicable)				72%

Note: WCAG conformance is ultimately pass/fail per page — any unmet Level AA criterion means the page does not fully conform. The percentage shows progress, not a passing grade; read it alongside the severity counts.

Findings

22 issues identified on the homepage, ordered by component and theme.

H-01 — No visible focus on list items

Serious

Component: Search-form dropdowns (Location, Occupation, etc.) | **WCAG:** 2.4.7 Focus Visible (AA)

Steps: Open a search-form dropdown (e.g. Locations), tab to the "Search for a location" field, then press Tab again to reach the first list item.

Expected: A clear, visible focus indicator on the list item.

Actual: There is no visible focus indicator, so I cannot tell which item has focus.

Recommendation: Rebuild the dropdown component (used by all search-form dropdowns) to follow the ARIA APG combobox + tree pattern: single tab stop; Up/Down move the active option (scrolled into view); Right/Left expand/collapse groups; Space/Enter toggles selection; Esc closes and returns focus to the field.

H-02 — Cannot reach the whole list

Serious

Component: Search-form dropdowns (Location, Occupation, etc.) | **WCAG:** 2.1.1 Keyboard (A)

Steps: Open the dropdown and use the keyboard to move down through the list of options.

Expected: The list scrolls to keep the focused option in view, so every option can be reached.

Actual: The list does not scroll, so options below the visible area cannot be seen or selected by keyboard.

Recommendation: Rebuild the dropdown component (used by all search-form dropdowns) to follow the ARIA APG combobox + tree pattern: single tab stop; Up/Down move the active option (scrolled into view); Right/Left expand/collapse groups; Space/Enter toggles selection; Esc closes and returns focus to the field.

H-03 — Focus leaves the open dropdown

Serious

Component: Search-form dropdowns (Location, Occupation, etc.) | **WCAG:** 2.4.3 Focus Order (A)

Steps: Tab to the "Clear all selections" button, then press Tab again.

Expected: Focus stays inside the open dropdown (or the dropdown closes).

Actual: The dropdown stays open, but focus moves out to the next field.

Recommendation: Rebuild the dropdown component (used by all search-form dropdowns) to follow the ARIA APG combobox + tree pattern: single tab stop; Up/Down move the active option (scrolled into view); Right/Left expand/collapse groups; Space/Enter toggles selection; Esc closes and returns focus to the field.

H-04 — Esc does not close the dropdown

Moderate

Component: Search-form dropdowns (Location, Occupation, etc.) | **WCAG:** 2.1.1 Keyboard (A)

Steps: Open the dropdown and press the Esc key.

Expected: The dropdown closes and focus returns to the field.

Actual: The dropdown stays open; Esc does nothing.

Recommendation: Rebuild the dropdown component (used by all search-form dropdowns) to follow the ARIA APG combobox + tree pattern: single tab stop; Up/Down move the active option (scrolled into view); Right/Left expand/collapse groups; Space/Enter toggles selection; Esc closes and returns focus to the field.

H-05 — Arrow keys scroll the whole page

Serious

Component: Search-form dropdowns (Location, Occupation, etc.) | **WCAG:** 2.1.1 Keyboard (A)

Steps: Focus the field, press Enter to open the dropdown, then press the Down-arrow key several times.
Expected: The arrow keys move the highlighted option down through the list, keeping it in view.
Actual: A grey highlight moves down the items, but real focus stays on the field and the whole page scrolls.

Recommendation: Rebuild the dropdown component (used by all search-form dropdowns) to follow the ARIA APG combobox + tree pattern: single tab stop; Up/Down move the active option (scrolled into view); Right/Left expand/collapse groups; Space/Enter toggles selection; Esc closes and returns focus to the field.

H-06 — No visible focus on header items

Serious

Component: Page header / top navigation | **WCAG:** 2.4.7 Focus Visible (AA)

Steps: Open the page and press Tab repeatedly through the header ("Skip to main content" appears first, then the "I work for NSW" logo link, "Sign in", and the menu items).

Expected: A visible focus indicator on each interactive item as it receives focus.

Actual: No focus indicator is visible, so a keyboard user cannot tell which item has focus.

Recommendation: Add a clearly visible focus indicator (e.g. a 2px outline or text underline with at least 3:1 contrast) to every interactive element in the header: the logo link, Sign in, and the menu items.

H-07 — "Skip to main content" does not move focus to main content

Serious

Component: Skip links (bypass mechanism) | **WCAG:** 2.4.1 Bypass Blocks (A)

Steps: Open the page, press Tab (the "Skip to main content" link appears), then press Enter.

Expected: Focus moves directly to the main content (the Search field).

Actual: Focus does not visibly move to the main content. Pressing Tab then reveals further skip links ("Skip to navigation", "Skip to content"), and several more Tab presses are needed before focus reaches the Search field.

Recommendation: Make the "Skip to main content" link move focus straight to the main landmark / Search field when activated. Place skip links at the very start of the tab order; do not require tabbing through several skip links to reach the main content.

H-08 — "Skip to navigation" link is placed where it serves no purpose

Minor

Component: Skip links (bypass mechanism) | **WCAG:** Usability (best practice)

Steps: Open the page and Tab through the header. After the "Skip to main content" link and the "Sign in" link, a "Skip to navigation" link appears - immediately before the navigation menu.

Expected: A "skip to navigation" link is only useful before the header content (to skip the logo and Sign in and jump to the navigation), or within/after the main content (to return to the navigation).

Actual: The link appears right before the navigation, when the user has already reached it by tabbing, so it serves no purpose. (Most sites simply provide a single "Skip to main content" link.)

Recommendation: Place skip links at the very start of the page's tab order so they can actually bypass the logo and Sign in. Remove or reposition the redundant "Skip to navigation" link that appears once the user is already at the navigation; a single "Skip to main content" link is usually sufficient.

H-09 — Submenu cannot be opened by keyboard

Moderate

Component: Main navigation (submenus) | **WCAG:** 2.1.1 Keyboard (A)

Steps: Tab to a top-level navigation item that has a submenu, then try to open the submenu with the keyboard, trying Enter, Space, the Down arrow, and the Right arrow in turn.

Expected: The submenu opens via the keyboard and its expanded state is conveyed.

Actual: None of these keys open the submenu, so it cannot be opened by keyboard at all and its links cannot be reached.

Recommendation: Implement keyboard support for the navigation per the ARIA APG (disclosure-navigation or menubar pattern): the submenu opens with the expected key(s), aria-expanded is exposed, submenu links are reachable, and focus is visible.

H-10 — Hamburger menu is not reachable or operable by keyboard

Critical

Component: Mobile navigation (hamburger menu) | **WCAG:** 2.1.1 Keyboard (A)

Steps: View the homepage in the narrow (mobile) layout, where the navigation is collapsed into a hamburger menu. Press Tab to try to reach and open the menu.

Expected: The hamburger button shows a visible focus indicator when focused and opens with Enter/Space to reveal the menu items.

Actual: The button cannot be reached or operated by keyboard and shows no focus indicator, so the menu items cannot be reached.

Recommendation: Make the hamburger control a keyboard-focusable button with a visible focus indicator and aria-expanded, openable with Enter/Space, so all navigation is reachable by keyboard in the mobile layout (ARIA APG disclosure pattern).

H-11 — No visible focus on main-content links and panels

Serious

Component: Main content (links & panels) | **WCAG:** 2.4.7 Focus Visible (AA)

Steps: Tab to the "Start your search" button, then keep pressing Tab through the rest of the page.

Expected: A visible focus indicator on each interactive element (e.g. the "Frontline services" panel and the links that follow).

Actual: No focus indicator is visible for most elements (the only exception is the "Learn more about sign in" button in the "Sign into a NSW organisation's job platform" block), so the user cannot tell where they are.

Recommendation: Apply a visible focus indicator to every interactive element on the page (links, buttons, panels). A single site-wide focus style is the cleanest fix.

H-12 — Dropdown announced as a plain button, not an expandable list

Moderate

Component: Search-form dropdowns (Location, Occupation) | **WCAG:** 4.1.2 Name, Role, Value (A)

Steps: With VoiceOver on, move to the Location dropdown and listen to how it is announced.

Expected: It is announced as an expandable control with its state - e.g. "Locations, combo box, collapsed" - so a screen-reader user knows it opens a list and whether it is open.

Actual: It is announced only as "Locations, button", with no indication that it opens a list and no expanded/collapsed state.

Recommendation: Expose proper combobox semantics: give the control a combobox/listbox role (or at minimum aria-haspopup='listbox' plus an aria-expanded state that updates), so screen readers announce it as an expandable control with its open/closed state. A clearer label such as 'Choose location' is a helpful addition, but the role and state are the essential fix.

H-13 — Revealed fields are easily missed; expanded state not announced

Serious

Component: Search form - "More options" disclosure | **WCAG:** 4.1.2 Name, Role, Value (A)

Steps: With VoiceOver on, focus the "More options" button and press Enter, then press Tab.

Expected: The button's expanded state is announced, and the newly revealed fields are easy to find by continuing forward.

Actual: Only the changed label "Less options" is announced - the expanded state is not. The new fields (Organisation, Work type, Salary) appear BEFORE the button, so pressing Tab moves forward to 'Start your search' and skips them; reaching them requires Shift+Tab, which nothing signals. A blind user may never discover the extra fields.

Recommendation: Add aria-expanded (and aria-controls) to the toggle so its state is announced. Move focus to the first revealed field when the section expands so it is discoverable. Do not rely on the label change alone.

H-14 — Opening the dropdown announces nothing

Serious

Component: Search-form dropdowns (Location, Occupation) | **WCAG:** 4.1.2 Name, Role, Value (A)

Steps: With VoiceOver on, focus the Location field and press Enter to open the dropdown.

Expected: VoiceOver announces that the control is now expanded and exposes the list of options that has appeared.

Actual: Nothing is announced when the dropdown opens, so a screen-reader user has no indication that the list appeared or that the control's state changed.

Recommendation: Expose the expanded/collapsed state on the control (aria-expanded) and ensure the revealed list is announced via proper combobox/listbox semantics, so activation communicates that the list has opened.

H-15 — Hidden "for screen reader" element creates a confusing empty stop

Moderate

Component: Search-form dropdowns (Location, Occupation) | **WCAG:** 4.1.2 Name, Role, Value (A) / 1.3.1 Info and Relationships (A)

Steps: With VoiceOver on, open the Location dropdown and press VO+Right past the "Search for a location" field.

Expected: Focus moves to the first option (checkbox) in the list.

Actual: VoiceOver lands on an empty element announced as "for screen reader, edit text" - a confusing stop that conveys no purpose before the options.

Recommendation: Remove or correctly label the hidden "for screen reader" element so it does not create a meaningless extra stop; users should move from the search field straight to the first option.

H-16 — "Sydney Region" is expandable for sighted users but not for screen readers

Serious

Component: Search-form dropdowns | **WCAG:** 4.1.2 Name, Role, Value (A)

Steps: With VoiceOver in Safari, open the Location dropdown and move to "Sydney Region".

Expected: VoiceOver conveys that the item can be ticked (to select the whole region) and expanded to reveal its sub-regions, and the sub-regions can be reached and selected.

Actual: VoiceOver announces the item only as "tick box, unticked". Control+Option+Space ticks it, but there is no indication that the item is expandable and no discoverable way to open or reach its sub-regions. A screen-reader user can select the whole region but cannot choose an individual sub-region.

Recommendation: Build the location hierarchy as an accessible multi-select tree (ARIA APG Tree View): expose the expandable state (aria-expanded), give a keyboard-operable way to expand and collapse each region, and make the sub-regions reachable and selectable by screen-reader and keyboard users.

H-17 — Landmark structure problems (duplicate/nested main, redundant nav label)

Moderate

Component: Page landmarks / structure | **WCAG:** 1.3.1 Info and Relationships (A)

Steps: With VoiceOver on, open the Rotor and review the Landmarks list; also inspect the landmark structure in the code.

Expected: Exactly one main landmark, not nested inside another landmark; navigation landmarks named only as needed and without repeating the word "navigation".

Actual: There are two main landmarks (there must be only one), a main is nested inside another landmark, and a navigation landmark's label includes the word "navigation" so VoiceOver announces "navigation navigation".

Recommendation: Use a single main landmark that is not nested inside any other landmark; name duplicate navs with a short label that omits the word 'navigation' (e.g. aria-label='Main' so VoiceOver says 'Main, navigation').

H-18 — Form labels marked up as headings (h4)

Minor

Component: Search form ("Find a job") | **WCAG:** 1.3.1 Info and Relationships (A) / 3.3.2 Labels or Instructions (A)

Steps: Inspect the "Find a job" search form in the code.

Expected: The form uses native HTML semantics - a form element, real labels programmatically associated with their controls, and standard form controls.

Actual: Field labels are marked up as headings (h4) and controls use SVG/custom markup instead of native form elements, so labels are not programmatically tied to their fields. Headings instead of labels confuse blind users who use the Rotor

Recommendation: Rebuild the search form with native semantics: a form element, labels correctly associated with each control (for/id or wrapping), and standard form controls, so the label-field relationships are exposed to assistive technology.

H-19 — Checkboxes disappear when CSS is turned off

Moderate

Component: Search-form dropdowns | **WCAG:** 1.3.1 Info and Relationships (A)

Steps: Turn off CSS (or use a "disable styles" tool), then open the "Find a job" form and look at the Location dropdown options.

Expected: With CSS off, the checkboxes still appear as real form controls, so locations can be selected.

Actual: With CSS off, no checkboxes are visible, so the user cannot see or select any locations - the "checkboxes" are not real, native controls.

Recommendation: Use real, native checkbox controls (or correctly-rolled ARIA controls that remain perceivable without CSS) so the selection controls are robust and not dependent on styling.

H-20 — Image alt text duplicates the card heading (verbose in some browsers)

Minor

Component: Content images (cards + "Better work" section) | **WCAG:** Usability (best practice)

Steps: Inspect the three "Explore where your skills can take you" cards (and the "Better work for a better NSW" image). Each card is a link that contains both a heading and an image whose alt text repeats that heading.

Expected: An image inside a link that already contains the heading should have empty alt text (alt=""), so the title is announced once.

Actual: The image alt text repeats the heading. In Safari, VoiceOver folds this into one accessible name and reads the title once; in Chrome it reads the title twice. The image does have a text alternative, so this is not a WCAG 1.1.1 failure - but the duplicate alt is redundant and causes a double read in some browsers.

Recommendation: For an image inside a link that already contains the heading text, use alt="" so the title is never announced twice in any browser.

H-21 — Card text overlaps arrow icon at increased text spacing

Moderate

Component: Content cards ("Our commitment...", "Adjustments...") | **WCAG:** 1.4.12 Text Spacing (AA)

Steps: On the homepage, apply the Text Spacing bookmarklet (line-height 1.5, paragraph spacing 2x, letter spacing 0.12x, word spacing 0.16x). Look at the "Our commitment to candidates" and "Adjustments for individual needs" cards.

Expected: With the increased spacing applied, all text remains fully visible and readable, with no overlap or clipping.

Actual: The body text grows beyond its fixed-height container and the last line overlaps the arrow icon (e.g. "feedback"), making content harder to read.

Recommendation: Do not constrain the card text to a fixed height; let the container grow with its content (use min-height instead of a fixed height) and keep the arrow in normal flow so it cannot overlap the text at increased spacing.

H-22 — Some mobile menu items are announced only as "Menu item", with no name

Serious

Component: Mobile menu items (Job Search, Sign in, Help) | **WCAG:** 4.1.2 Name, Role, Value (A)

Steps: On iPhone (iOS, Safari) with VoiceOver on, open the mobile menu and swipe through the items.

Expected: Each menu item is announced with its visible name (e.g. "Job Search", "Sign in", "Help").

Actual: "Job Search", "Sign in" and "Help" are announced only as "Menu item", with no name, so a VoiceOver user cannot tell them apart or know where each leads. Other items in the same menu (Work for NSW, Employment programs, How to apply) are announced correctly, which shows names can be exposed.

Recommendation: Give each menu item a proper accessible name - real text in the link, or an aria-label where the item is icon-based - so every item is announced by name.

H-23 — Open mobile menu cannot be closed or escaped; focus is not managed

Serious

Component: Mobile menu (open state), Close button | **WCAG:** 2.4.3 Focus Order (A) / 4.1.2 Name, Role, Value (A)

Steps: On iPhone (iOS, Safari) with VoiceOver on, open the mobile menu, swipe to the last item, then keep swiping.

Expected: Focus stays within the open menu; a "Close" control is reachable; closing the menu (including the two-finger scrub) returns focus to the menu button.

Actual: Swiping past the last item moves focus to the browser "back" link, not a Close control; the "Close" button inside the menu cannot be reached by swiping; swiping back lands in page content while the menu stays open. The two-finger scrub dismisses the menu but returns focus to the browser, not the menu button or page content. A VoiceOver user is left disoriented with no clear way back to the main content.

Recommendation: Build the mobile menu as a proper dialog/disclosure: keep VoiceOver focus within it while open, expose a reachable "Close" control, return focus to the menu button on close, and support the standard dismiss gesture.

H-24 — Menu button announced only as "menu" - role and state not exposed

Moderate

Component: Mobile menu button (hamburger) | **WCAG:** 4.1.2 Name, Role, Value (A)

Steps: On iPhone (iOS, Safari) with VoiceOver on, move to the hamburger menu control.

Expected: VoiceOver announces it as a button, with its name and expanded/collapsed state (e.g. "Menu, button, collapsed").

Actual: VoiceOver announces only "menu" - it does not convey that the control is a button, nor whether the menu is expanded or collapsed, so a screen-reader user is not told it is actionable or what state it is in.

Recommendation: Expose the control as a native button (or role="button") with an accessible name and an aria-expanded state, so VoiceOver announces its role and whether the menu is open.

H-25 — Card arrow is a separate link announced only as "east"

Moderate

Component: Content cards ("Explore where your skills can take you") | **WCAG:** 2.4.4 Link Purpose (In Context) (A)

Steps: On iPhone (iOS, Safari) with VoiceOver on, set the rotor to Links and move through a card in the "Explore where your skills can take you" section.

Expected: The card is a single link named by its heading (e.g. "Frontline services"), so its purpose is clear.

Actual: Each card exposes three separate links - the heading, the description and the arrow - and the arrow link's only accessible name is "east" (the icon's internal name), which does not convey where it goes. Three adjacent links to the same destination is also redundant for screen-reader users.

Recommendation: Make each card a single link named by its heading, and hide the decorative arrow from assistive technology (aria-hidden="true" or empty alt) so the link name comes only from its text.

WCAG 2.2 Level A & AA checklist

All 55 Level A and AA success criteria with the result recorded during the evaluation.

Principle 1 — Perceivable

SC	Success criterion	Lvl	Result
1.1.1	Non-text Content	A	Pass
1.2.1	Audio-only and Video-only (Prerecorded)	A	Not applicable
1.2.2	Captions (Prerecorded)	A	Not applicable
1.2.3	Audio Description or Media Alternative (Prerecorded)	A	Not applicable
1.2.4	Captions (Live)	AA	Not applicable
1.2.5	Audio Description (Prerecorded)	AA	Not applicable
1.3.1	Info and Relationships	A	Fail
1.3.2	Meaningful Sequence	A	Pass
1.3.3	Sensory Characteristics	A	Not applicable
1.3.4	Orientation	AA	Pass
1.3.5	Identify Input Purpose	AA	Not applicable
1.4.1	Use of Color	A	Not applicable
1.4.2	Audio Control	A	Not applicable
1.4.3	Contrast (Minimum)	AA	Pass
1.4.4	Resize Text	AA	Pass
1.4.5	Images of Text	AA	Pass
1.4.10	Reflow	AA	Pass
1.4.11	Non-text Contrast	AA	Pass
1.4.12	Text Spacing	AA	Fail
1.4.13	Content on Hover or Focus	AA	Not applicable

Principle 2 — Operable

SC	Success criterion	Lvl	Result
2.1.1	Keyboard	A	Fail
2.1.2	No Keyboard Trap	A	Pass
2.1.4	Character Key Shortcuts	A	Not applicable
2.2.1	Timing Adjustable	A	Not applicable
2.2.2	Pause, Stop, Hide	A	Not applicable
2.3.1	Three Flashes or Below Threshold	A	Not applicable
2.4.1	Bypass Blocks	A	Fail
2.4.2	Page Titled	A	Pass
2.4.3	Focus Order	A	Fail
2.4.4	Link Purpose (In Context)	A	Fail
2.4.5	Multiple Ways	AA	Pass
2.4.6	Headings and Labels	AA	Pass
2.4.7	Focus Visible	AA	Fail
2.4.11	Focus Not Obscured (Minimum)	AA	Pass

SC	Success criterion	Lvl	Result
2.5.1	Pointer Gestures	A	Not applicable
2.5.2	Pointer Cancellation	A	Pass
2.5.3	Label in Name	A	Pass
2.5.4	Motion Actuation	A	Not applicable
2.5.7	Dragging Movements	AA	Not applicable
2.5.8	Target Size (Minimum)	AA	Pass

Principle 3 — Understandable

SC	Success criterion	Lvl	Result
3.1.1	Language of Page	A	Pass
3.1.2	Language of Parts	AA	Not applicable
3.2.1	On Focus	A	Pass
3.2.2	On Input	A	Pass
3.2.3	Consistent Navigation	AA	Pass
3.2.4	Consistent Identification	AA	Pass
3.2.6	Consistent Help	A	Pass
3.3.1	Error Identification	A	Not applicable
3.3.2	Labels or Instructions	A	Fail
3.3.3	Error Suggestion	AA	Not applicable
3.3.4	Error Prevention (Legal, Financial, Data)	AA	Not applicable
3.3.7	Redundant Entry	A	Pass
3.3.8	Accessible Authentication (Minimum)	AA	Not applicable

Principle 4 — Robust

SC	Success criterion	Lvl	Result
4.1.2	Name, Role, Value	A	Fail
4.1.3	Status Messages	AA	Not applicable